

Eric Carle Museum spotlights the medium of picture book art

The museum shares its appreciation for picture book art with the community

By George Coulouras, Assistant News Editor

When you think of fine art, picture book illustrations from your childhood may not spring to mind. The mission of the Eric Carle Museum of Picture Book Art is to change that perception.

“The museum was founded with a simple but powerful idea: picture book art is fine art that belongs on the walls of a museum,” Jennifer Schantz, the museum’s executive director, said.

The museum cares for over 20,000 original works from more than 300 artists, including over 5,000 works from Eric Carle, a renowned children’s book author and illustrator best known for writing and illustrating “The Very Hungry Caterpillar”.

“I think there’s something about the picture book that makes artwork feel inviting and accessible, something that we know and can do,” David Feinstein, a literacy educator at the museum, said.

Carle and his wife, Barbara, were inspired to create the museum after a trip to Japan, where they observed museums dedicated to picture book art. The Carles founded the museum in 2002 on land purchased from Hampshire College.

Today, the museum remains committed to honoring Carle’s memory and sharing his love of picture book art with the surrounding community.

“The philosophies that we have in the studio, that openness to create and the way that we get children to think about picture books, is the best way that we can respect Eric’s legacy,” Natalie Jasmin, the museum’s education coordinator, said.

While the museum seeks to create an engaging experience for first-time museum goers, oftentimes young children, the museum does not represent itself as solely for children.

“I think sometimes people say, ‘Oh that’s a children’s museum.’ I would say it is really an art museum,” Bella Moses, a museum store employee and English MFA student at UMass, said. “There are events that are applicable to people of all ages, and it’s a fun place to go and escape.”

The museum recently launched a program called “Carle After Dark” to target an older audience, in which the museum holds a special event after museum hours on the first Thursday of every month. The most recent After Dark event was a collaboration with the UMass Fashion Organization.



Photo courtesy of The Eric Carle Museum of Picture Book Art Facebook

While Carle wrote over 70 books in his career, he is most widely known for his 1969 book “The Very Hungry Caterpillar”. A copy of the famous book is sold somewhere in the world every 30 seconds.

However, the famed caterpillar does not have the presence at the museum that some attendees expect. According to Isabel Ruiz Cano, the museum’s associate curator, the original artwork from the book is not on display due to its fragility and sensitivity to light exposure.

While there are nods to the caterpillar throughout the museum — most notably a hungry caterpillar-shaped reading nook — the museum does not want the character to be the sole focus.

“We see [the Very Hungry Caterpillar] as sort of our entry way. That’s our hook for people to come here,” Ruiz Cano said. “And then it’s a pleasure to be able to introduce them to everything else that Eric Carle did, and all these other wonderful illustrators.”

Beyond established picture book artists like Carle, the museum also platforms modern-day picture book authors and illustrators, with an emphasis on highlighting diverse perspectives.

The museum is currently preparing for an exhibit surrounding “The Past, Present and Future of Indigenous Picture Book Art”, expected to open in January 2027.

Ultimately, the intergenerational connection to picture book art is something that the museum hopes to maintain.

“People have such fond memories of interacting with picture book art, and I think it’s very important to be able to conserve it for the future, to pay homage to those memories that people create,” Ruiz Cano said.

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